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The Man behind the Machine

The Indian Army has for long been visionary in its approach to welfare of all ranks. I had made it an act of faith to improve the service conditions of all ranks of the army and lead a well-trained, happy, highly motivated and spirited team. With this in mind, I pushed for an assured career progression plan for officers and men. The scale and number of soldiers who would benefit from this initiative would certainly have far-reaching implications on the morale and satisfaction levels of our soldiers. The sepoys, non-commissioned officers and junior commissioned officers would be eligible for 'three steps assured' progression in their careers. For instance, a soldier would be assured of the pay scale of a naik (corporal), a havildar (sergeant) and a junior commissioned officer after putting in eight, sixteen and twenty-four years of service respectively. The government approved this proposal and it has been implemented from 1 January 2008. The officers too would get a time-scale promotion to the rank of colonel on completion of twenty-six years of service. While implementing the A.V. Singh Committee (Part II) recommendations, there was a lot of wrangling by the other services to try and corner more posts of two- or three-star ranks. I stood my ground and insisted that the distribution of these additional vacancies be on a pro-rata basis. The other two services already had an edge vis-à-vis the army and I didn't want the situation to be skewed further. The problem got accentuated in the tri-service institutions where the juniors in service belonging to the navy or air force would be commanding their seniors from the army, because of this differential. Eventually, logic prevailed and we got a fair deal.